

10-Point Checklist for Identifying Phishing Emails

Is the sender's email address legitimate?

- Look for subtle misspellings or fake domains (e.g., @micros0ft.com vs. @microsoft.com)

Is the greeting generic?

- "Dear Customer" instead of using your real name can be a red flag.

Does the email ask for personal info or passwords?

- No legitimate organization will ask you to send sensitive info via email.

Is there a sense of urgency or a threat?

- Phrases like "Act now" or "Your account will be suspended" are common phishing tactics.

Are there spelling or grammar issues?

- Even AI-generated emails can slip up—read carefully for unusual phrasing.

Does it seem too good to be true?

- Free money, prizes, refunds? Be skeptical.

Where does the link actually go?

- Hover over links to preview the real URL before clicking. Don't trust link text.

Are there unexpected attachments?

- Be especially wary of .zip, .docx, .xlsm, or .exe files.

Does the tone or request seem unusual for the sender?

- Would your CEO really ask you to buy gift cards via email?

Can you verify the request another way?

- When in doubt, contact the sender through a known, trusted channel.